

When the curse wore off and Heracles realized what he had done, he was devastated. He decided to go to the Pythia for advice. The Pythia was a priestess of Apollo, famous for her wisdom. “You must go to King Eurystheus,” she told him. “If you complete the tasks he gives you, then you will be forgiven and made immortal like your father, Zeus.”

Heracles went straight to Eurystheus’ palace. However, the king was one of Hera’s most loyal worshipers. Eurystheus agreed to give Heracles 12 tasks to complete, but the king had no intention of making the labors easy.

The first task Eurystheus set was to slay the Nemean lion. He wanted the beast’s skin because no weapon could pierce it. When Heracles tried to shoot the lion with arrows, each one bounced off its golden fur. Instead, Heracles jumped onto the roaring cat’s back and strangled it with his bare hands.

*Heracles carried the huge lion back to the palace.*

When Eurystheus saw him approaching the gates, he was terrified by Heracles’s might and refused to meet him. Eurystheus sent a messenger to tell Heracles what his next task was, and that he could keep the lion’s skin.

*Heracles wrestled the lion to the ground.*

